

THE RIME OF
THE
ANCIENT MARINER

Samuel Taylor Coleridge

1834

PART I

It is an ancient Mariner,
And he stoppeth one of three.
'By thy long grey beard and
glittering eye,
Now wherefore stopp'st thou
me?

The Bridegroom's doors are
opened wide,
And I am next of kin;
The guests are met, the feast is
set:
May'st hear the merry din.'

He holds him with his skinny
hand,
'There was a ship,' quoth he.
'Hold off! unhand me,
grey-beard loon!'
Eftsoons his hand dropt he.

He holds him with his
glittering eye—
The Wedding-Guest stood
still,
And listens like a three years'
child:
The Mariner hath his will.

The Wedding-Guest sat on a
stone:
He cannot choose but hear;
And thus spake on that
ancient man,
The bright-eyed Mariner.

"The ship was cheered, the
harbour cleared,
Merrily did we drop
Below the kirk, below the hill,
Below the lighthouse top.

The Sun came up upon the

left,

Out of the sea came he!

And he shone bright, and on

the right

Went down into the sea.

Higher and higher every day,
Till over the mast at noon—'
The Wedding-Guest here beat
his breast,
For he heard the loud bassoon.

The bride hath paced into the
hall,
Red as a rose is she;
Nodding their heads before
her goes
The merry minstrelsy.

The Wedding-Guest he beat
his breast,
Yet he cannot choose but hear;
And thus spake on that
ancient man,
The bright-eyed Mariner.

And now the STORM-BLAST

came, and he
Was tyrannous and strong:
He struck with his o'ertaking
wings,
And chased us south along.

With sloping masts and
dipping prow,
As who pursued with yell and
blow
Still treads the shadow of his
foe,
And forward bends his head,
The ship drove fast, loud
roared the blast,
And southward aye we fled.

And now there came both
mist and snow,
And it grew wondrous cold:
And ice, mast-high, came
floating by,

As green as emerald.

And through the drifts the
snowy clifts

Did send a dismal sheen:

Nor shapes of men nor beasts
we ken—

The ice was all between.

The ice was here, the ice was
there,

The ice was all around:
It cracked and growled, and
roared and howled,
Like noises in a swound!

At length did cross an
Albatross,
Thorough the fog it came;
As if it had been a Christian
soul,
We hailed it in God's name.

It ate the food it ne'er had eat,
And round and round it flew.
The ice did split with a
thunder-fit;
The helmsman steered us
through!

And a good south wind

sprung up behind;
The Albatross did follow,
And every day, for food or
play,
Came to the mariner's hollo!

In mist or cloud, on mast or
shroud,
It perched for vespers nine;
Whiles all the night, through
fog-smoke white,
Glimmered the white
Moon-shine.'

'God save thee, ancient
Mariner!
From the fiends, that plague
thee thus!—
Why look'st thou so?'—With
my cross-bow
I shot the ALBATROSS.